who could effectively rebut his message are the retired generals and spies. A longer cooling-off period put them squarely on the sidelines; depending on the timing of elections, an ex-security chief with political aspirations could have to wait seven years to challenge Netanyahu—plenty of time for their stars to fade, both literally and figuratively.

## *The falafel story*

On a gray, rainy day in March, Netanyahu drove up to northern Israel to eulogize one of his sharpest critics.

Even by the standards of the Mossad, Israel's storied spy service, Meir Dagan was a legendary figure. Under his tutelage the agency assassinated Imad Mughniyeh, one of Hezbollah's top military commanders, on the streets of Damascus. It blew up Iranian nuclear scientists commuting to work. Muhammad Suleiman, a top Syrian general, was gunned down while hosting a dinner party at his home in Tartous. In 2010 *Al-Ahram*, the largest state-run newspaper in Egypt, called him "Superman".

After his retirement, though, Dagan had only one target: his former boss. Netanyahu spent several years threatening an Israeli airstrike against Iran's nuclear program. But Dagan, like much of the Israeli intelligence community, believed that such a move was premature: the regime in Tehran was still years away from actually producing a bomb. He doubted that tiny Israel could effectively neutralize Iran's nuclear facilities, which were spread across the country, some in well-fortified bunkers. It could only deal a temporary setback—and that tactical victory would be a strategic defeat, because it would justify Iran's pursuit of nuclear weapons and accelerate the program. Along with Gabi Ashkenazi and Yuval Diskin, the heads of the army and the Shin Bet, he spent his last year in office quietly fighting Netanyahu.

In the summer of 2010, Netanyahu asked Dagan and Ashkenazi to stay for a private chat after a security cabinet meeting. He wanted to give them a shocking order: he told them to accelerate plans for a strike, so that by the end of the summer the air force would be ready to move at a few hours' notice. Ashkenazi pushed back, calling it a "strategic mistake" and warning that Iran might notice the preparations and attack preemptively. Dagan was even more blunt. "This is an illegal order," he said. Israeli law requires the security cabinet to approve a war. With his three security chiefs opposed to